

ENG510

➡ What is Sociolinguistics?

Sociolinguistics studies the relationship between language and society, examining how language use varies across social contexts.

➡ Some Definitions of Sociolinguistics

- The study of language in social contexts
- The examination of language variation and change
- The analysis of language as a social phenomenon

➡ Sociolinguistics and Linguistics

Sociolinguistics complements linguistics by focusing on language use beyond structural analysis.

➡ Sociolinguistics and the Sociology of Language

Sociolinguistics overlaps with sociology of language, but focuses on language-specific issues.

➡ Sociolinguistics and Other Disciplines

- Anthropology
- Sociology
- Psychology
- Education

➡ Sociolinguistic Phenomena include:

- Language variation
- Language change
- Language contact
- Language attitudes

➡ Varieties of Language include:

- Dialects
- Registers
- Jargons

- Idiolects

➡ Linguistic Items

- Phonological
- Morphological
- Syntactic
- Lexical

➡ Variety and Lect

- Variety: a language subset
- Lect: a specific language variety

➡ Varieties of language:

- Regional dialects
- Social dialects
- Occupational dialects
- Ethnic dialects

➡ Language attitudes:

- Prestige
- Stigma
- Neutral

➡ Speech Communities

Speech communities are:

- Groups sharing language norms
- Social networks
- Language repertoires

➡ Intersecting Communities

Communities intersect through:

- Overlapping membership
- Shared language practices

➡ Rejecting the Idea of Speech Communities

Critics argue speech communities are:

- Too broad
- Too narrow
- Too static

→ **Networks and Repertoires**

- Describe language use
- Explain language variation

→ **Access to the Codes**

- Influences language use
- Affects language change

→ **Rigidity of the Social Matrix**

- Restricts language change
- Maintains language norms

→ **Variables and Variants**

- Describe language variation
- Explain language change

→ **Synchronic Variation**

Studies language variation at a single point

→ **Diachronic Variation**

Studies language change over time

→ **Some Examples of Dialects**

Dialects:

- Regional (e.g., Southern American)
- Social (e.g., African American Vernacular)
- Occupational (e.g., Medical jargon)

→ **Standard Languages**

- Official recognition
- Widespread use

➡ The Delimitation of Languages

Language delimitation:

- Geographic
- Cultural
- Linguistic criteria

➡ The Family Tree Model

The family tree model illustrates language relationships, showing how languages diverge and evolve.

➡ Regional Dialects

Regional dialects vary geographically, reflecting local culture and history.

➡ Social Dialects

Social dialects emerge from social factors like class, ethnicity, or occupation.

➡ Idiolects

Idiolects are unique individual language varieties.

➡ Dialects and Identity

Dialects often reflect speakers' identity, including regional, social, or cultural affiliations.

➡ Study of Dialects in Sociolinguistics

Sociolinguistics examines dialects to understand language variation and social context.

➡ Language and Dialect

Language and dialect distinctions are often blurry, with dialects sometimes considered languages.

➡ Regional Dialectology

Regional dialectology studies geographic language variation.

➡ The Work of Labov

William Labov's research on language variation and change pioneered sociolinguistics.

➡ **Martha's Vineyard**

Labov's Martha's Vineyard study demonstrated how social factors influence language.

➡ **Register**

A register is a language variety associated with specific contexts or purposes.

➡ **Examples of Register**

Registers include:

- Formal
- Informal
- Technical
- Literary

➡ **Register vs. Dialect**

Registers differ from dialects in their contextual dependence.

➡ **Jargon**

Jargon is specialized vocabulary used within professions or groups.

➡ **Accent**

Accent refers to pronunciation characteristics.

➡ **Accents vs. Dialect**

Accents differ from dialects in focusing on pronunciation rather than vocabulary/grammar.

➡ **Style**

Style concerns language choices in specific contexts.

➡ **Register vs. Style**

Registers are more formal, while style is more flexible.

➡ **Speech Communities and Communicative Competence**

Speech communities share language norms, and communicative competence enables effective communication.

➡ Code

Code refers to language varieties or systems.

➡ Bilingualism

Bilingualism involves proficiency in two languages.

➡ Bilinguality vs. Bilingualism

Bilinguality emphasizes individual language ability, while bilingualism focuses on societal language use.

➡ Bi/Multilingualism and Sociolinguistics

Sociolinguistics examines bilingualism/multilingualism in social contexts.

➡ Measuring Bilingualism

Bilingualism is measured through:

- Proficiency tests
- Language use surveys

➡ Code Switching and Sociolinguistics

Code switching involves alternating languages or varieties.

➡ Code Mixing and Sociolinguistics

Code mixing combines languages or varieties within utterances.

➡ Tag Switching

Tag switching involves inserting words/phrases from another language.

➡ Why Code Switching and Mixing?

Code switching/mixing facilitates communication, expresses identity, or navigates social contexts.

➡ Hybridization

Hybridization creates new language forms through blending.

➡ Social Correlates

Social correlates include:

- Social class
- Gender
- Age
- Ethnicity

➡ Politeness and Sociolinguistics

Politeness concerns language use to maintain social relationships.

➡ Power in Sociolinguistics

Power influences language use, with dominant groups often imposing language norms.

➡ Language and Ideology

Language reflects and reinforces societal ideologies.

➡ Ideology of Standard Language

Standard language ideologies promote a single, "correct" language variety.

➡ Language Shift

Language shift occurs when communities abandon their native language.

➡ Language Desertion

Language desertion involves abandoning a language without replacing it.

➡ Language Death

Language death occurs when a language falls out of use.

➡ Language Accommodation

Language accommodation involves adjusting language to converge with or diverge from others.

➡ Creole Origins and Structures

Creoles emerge from contact between languages.

The Creole Continuum

The creole continuum models language variation from pidgin to creole.

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